ficers transferred. However, all the sudden mobility was not without turbulence: chief secretary Manoj Ahuja had to issue a stern warning on November 11, threatening disciplinary action against officers allegedly trying to influence postings.

'Our CM'. How did that image-making begin? Again, as a gesture of contradistinction. Anil Biswal, a BJP spokesperson, says the old CM's grievance cell at the secretariat seemed like "a corporate office" to them. "It seemed as if the BJD's social media cell operated from these rooms, not a people outreach." After a complete overhaul, Majhi chaired his first in-person session on July 1. It was the first time in 15 years that a CM had personally taken such a session—Naveen held his last one in August 2008. Majhi plans to chair bi-monthly sessions in Bhubaneswar. If things go as planned, three more grievance cells will be opened to cater to the northern, western and southern districts.

The idea is to project Majhi as an accessible CM, unlike Naveen, who could never quite overcome the impression of being aloof—from the people and, ringed by bureaucrats as he was, also from his ministers. Law minister Prithiviraj Harichandan claims the new government has shifted from 'top-down' to 'consensual' as the framework for decision-making. "The CM, his two deputies and 6-7 of us are part of a core group," he says. All policy matters are discussed and debated, with the CM seeking suggestions, then taking a call. "It's never any individual's decision. He always listens to what we have to say."

This is of course a complex game, with a few contra-strands. Despite winning a majority of 78 in the 147-seat assembly, the BJP was behind the BJD in terms of vote share. Besides that negative margin of 9.03 million votes, the BJP is also a little vexed with the widely held belief that Naveen is still the most popular leader in the state. That falls squarely on the new CM, who is still at a safe distance from having convinced everyone as a figure of leadership. The perception of being a relatively lightweight New Delhi appointee still attaches to him. Majhi is seen to be Modi's pick, but most of his cabinet bears the imprint of central heavyweights from Odisha. "One can presume most key decisions are taken directly by the Centre," says political analyst Rabi Das. "Majhi is a good person, but not very popular." Apart from an image makeover, Majhi needs to espouse a vision and have it executed for the state's economic growth as Naveen did in his 24-year tenure.

Stamp of Holiness

Some succour comes from the Jagannath temple, which offers a feast of symbolic diversions. Its *ratna bhandar* (jewel treasury) was opened after 46 years, with a full complement of rituals. A posse of snake-charmers joined the Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force, just in case there was anything to the legend of serpents guarding the stow! Taking a cue from the Tirupati laddoo scandal, the ghee for puja and bhog was ordained to be sourced only from the Odisha State Cooperative Milk Producers' Federation. CCTV cameras are planned for the entire town of Puri to study and streamline pilgrim footfalls.

Await a spate of symbolism: the 18th Pravasi Bharatiya Divas to be hosted in January; a high-profile Odia Asmita Bhavan in Bhubaneswar, with architect Bimal Patel likely in on it; the 125th birth anniversary of Odisha's first CM Harekrushna Mahatab, to reverse the alleged BJD-era erasure of the legacy of all past icons barring Naveen's father Biju Patnaik. The spree of renaming of old schemes serves that aim too. Will all this work to sow Majhi in Odisha's psychological soil? Such questions are best asked of the deities. ■



REINFORCING ODIA PRIDE

The Majhi government has turned the poll plank of Odia *asmita*, seen as a linchpin of the BJP's victory, into a robust governance idea

- **All four gates of the Jagannath temple opened**
- **The temple's *ratna bhandar* opened after 46 years**
- **Ater the Tirupati laddoo row, the ghee for puja/bhog was ordained to be sourced only from the state's own milk coop. federation**
- **The Odisha Bridge and Construction Corporation asked to design a blueprint to streamline pilgrim movement inside the temple**
- **A Jagannath research centre is planned, with libraries and AI-powered museums**
- **The government has decided to allocate Rs 10-12 crore as annual monetary aid to 18,000-odd other temples**
- **In January, the state will host the 18th Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, jointly with the Ministry of External Affairs**
- **A five-acre Odia Asmita Bhavan is being planned in Bhubaneswar at an approx. cost of Rs 300 crore; architect Bimal Patel likely in**
- **On November 21, the state began observing the year-long 125th birth anniversary of Odisha's first CM Harekrushna Mahatab, to reverse the alleged BJD-era erasure of the legacy of past icons barring Biju Patnaik, Naveen's father**

